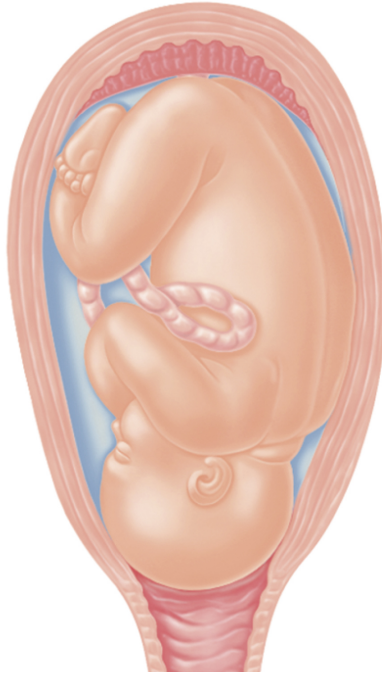




At 10 cm dilation, you are fully dilated. Contractions may be very frequent and you are nearly ready to start pushing your baby out.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Am I likely to have medical interventions in labor in the hospital?

If the reason for having a hospital birth is because you or your baby are at a higher risk of developing complications, there may be an increased need for interventions to keep you and your baby safe. Some interventions include artificially opening the bag of waters if your labor progress has slowed or if there is a concern about the baby's heart rate; inserting a catheter if you are unable to pass urine; placing an intravenous drip through which fluids or medication can be given if, for example, you are at high risk of a postpartum hemorrhage or you need intravenous antibiotics for group B Streptococcus; and helping to augment labor with medications.

Is artificial rupture of the membranes routine in the hospital?

Manually breaking the bag of waters, known as amniotomy or ARM (see [Breaking the water](#)), is offered routinely in some hospitals. It's a painless, low-risk procedure thought to shorten the time of labor by one to two hours, reduce the chance of a low early [Apgar score](#) in your baby, and significantly decrease the chance that you'll need medication to [speed up labor](#). Amniotomy does, however, increase the intensity of contractions. The one time it is necessary is if a fetal [scalp electrode](#) is put on the baby's head as this can't be done without breaking the waters. It will also be done as part of the induction process (see [Induction of labor](#)).

How is labor sped up with drugs?

If labor is not progressing, it can be augmented by using oxytocin given through the IV to strengthen contractions. This is done in conjunction with continuous fetal monitoring to watch for signs of distress if the contractions are too frequent. Oxytocin is metabolized very quickly so turning off the IV will stop the contractions within a few minutes.

Transition